
Emily Wilson to retranslate the Odyssey from scratch

Writer who criticised Christopher Nolan film based on her 2017 translation is working on new version of Homer's poem

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Photograph: Matt Rourke/AP

Emily Wilson, the first woman to translate Homer's *Odyssey* into English, is to retranslate the ancient Greek epic poem from scratch less than a decade after the publication of her acclaimed version.

The announcement comes after Wilson attracted controversy this summer with a scathing assessment of Christopher Nolan's blockbuster film adaptation of the *Odyssey*, which she slammed for its "abysmal" writing and lack of sex scenes.

Wilson's 2017 translation became a bestseller and was praised for making the 3,000-year-old epic poem modern and accessible.

"I'm now retranslating the *Odyssey* from scratch, with an approach closer to that of my translation of the *Iliad*, using somewhat more lines than the original, enabling more varied word-length and pacing," she told the *New York Times*.

"It's a complete retranslation. It's not a revision of the old version," she told the AP. "I'm about halfway through."

Nolan cited Wilson's 2017 translation, including its opening sentence, "Tell me about a complicated man", as an influence on his adaptation of the poem, released in July this year and starring Tom Holland, Zendaya, Matt Damon and Anne Hathaway.

Nolan's adaptation took the global box office by storm, making \$264m (£196m) during its opening weekend, marking the director's best ever opening. Book sales saw a huge bump too: UK print sales of the poem increased by 1,400% in the four weeks to 25 July compared with the same period in 2025, after the film's release in the middle of the month.

Wilson made headlines for her attack on Nolan's version. Writing in the *London Review of Books*, she said: "Nolan's *Odyssey* lacks many of the elements that make the poem great ... The writing is abysmal."

She continued: "None of the characters has convincing motivation for their actions or words. There are no sex scenes, and all the food looks horrible," adding, "I would be ashamed to have written any part of this script."

Her criticism attracted strong reactions, including from novelist Joyce Carol Oates, who accused Wilson of "haughty superiority".

Wilson's decision to retranslate the poem predates the row over the film. In an interview recorded in the spring for the ancient-history podcast *Instant Classics*, she discussed her desire to return to Homer and approach the poem differently from her first translation.

"I'm proud of my *Odyssey* translation ... I think there are lots of good things about the kinds of compression and choices that I was forced into," Wilson said then.

She has indicated that she will "probably" keep the opening line, "Tell me about a complicated man". Wilson also added that her original translation relied too heavily on the word "slave", when more precise terminology could have better reflected the different forms of enslavement depicted in the poem.

The new translation will also give readers far more of Wilson's scholarly commentary. "I'm also going to quadruple the number of endnotes because endnotes are really fun to write," she said.

While Wilson's decision to retranslate Homer's poem is unusual, it is not without precedent.

"Translators quite often rework or rewrite their own previous translations," said Matthew Reynolds, professor of English and comparative criticism at Oxford University.

"Elizabeth Barrett Browning completely rewrote her translation of Aeschylus's Prometheus Bound, Ezra Pound repeatedly revised his translations of Guido Cavalcanti, and Yu JongHo (유종호) translated Jane Eyre into Korean first in 1970 and again in 2004."

He added: "It shows that translation – especially literary translation – is not just a matter of right or wrong, good or bad, but a continual exploratory process of interpretive reimagining and re-making."

Wilson's new Odyssey does not yet have a publication date.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
retranslate	v.	重译、重新翻译	re-（再次）+ translate；名词 retranslation
from scratch	短语	从零开始、从头做起	retranslate from scratch = 推倒重来地重译
scathing	adj.	严厉尖刻的	scathing assessment / criticism
slam	v.	猛烈抨击	新闻口语，≈ strongly criticise
blockbuster	n.	大片；轰动性作品	“票房炸弹”；近义 a box-office hit
box office	n.	票房（收入）	第二义项：不是“售票 处”
take ... by storm	短语	席卷、迅速征服	took the global box office by storm

词	词性	中文	备注
bump	n.	(数量的) 跃升	a huge bump (本义是“撞、颠簸”)
release	n./v.	上映; 发行	第二义项: the film's release = 电影上映
row	n.	争吵、风波	读 /raʊ/; 英式新闻高频 (≠“行列”)
predate	v.	早于、先于	pre- + date; 反义 postdate
precedent	n.	先例	not without precedent = 并非没有先例
rework	v.	改写、重做	rework / rewrite a translation
revise	v.	修订、修改	第二义项: 英式英语里 revise 还指“复习”
haughty	adj.	傲慢的、居高临下的	“haughty superiority”傲慢的优越感
abysmal	adj.	糟透的	≈ dreadful、terrible
quadruple	v.	(使) 成四倍	quadruple the number of endnotes
endnote	n.	尾注 (书末注释)	footnote 脚注 vs endnote 尾注